

REU Student Orientation

These slides are on our GitHub page.

Welcome!

CIERA REU Leadership:

Cliff Johnson

Research Faculty & REU Director

Mark Gorski

Research Faculty & REU Co-director

Day 1 (Tuesday, June 23)

- 9:30: Meet and Greet
- 10:00: More Intros, Tech Setup, Orientation
- 11:00-1:00: Campus tour + lunch (try CatCash or you bring/buy)
- 2-5pm: Meet with mentor(s)
- 5:30pm: Dinner (CIERA buys)
 - Meet in 8th Floor Sky Lounge at ~5:00pm

Intro Activity

**Partner Intros:
Basics &
Mundane Superpower**

Mentors & Projects

Student	Institution	Mentor
Kya Aranha (she/her)	Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute	Miller/Hinkle
Laya Binu (she/her)	University of California, San Diego	Kalogera/Ray/Gossage
Abhi Ghosh (he/him)	Boston University	Starkenburg
Mariam Helal (she/her)	University of California, Berkeley	Mulyukova
Vincent Hernandez (he/him)	Williams College	Wang
Braedyn Kim (she/her)	University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign	Faucher-Giguere/Su
Meredith LeFevre (she/they)	University of Iowa	Johnson
Luke Moffett (he/him)	Dartmouth College	Eftekhari
Max Morris (he/him)	Carleton College	Novak
Ben Spangler (he/him)	Colorado State University Pueblo	Gorski
Matt Tie (he/him)	Haverford College	Tchekhovskoy
Aly Tran (she/her)	University of Texas at Austin	Strom
Rebecca Wisenbaker (she/her)	University of Texas at Austin	Kilpatrick

Our Role: We're Here for You!

Cliff Johnson & Mark Gorski

- Support positive mentor-mentee relationships
 - “Open door” policy for both mentors & mentees
 - Confidentiality (but mandated reporters)
- Logistics / Admin / IT support (see also: Michail)
- REU Group Meeting: 7-600, Friday 3:30-4:30pm
- Cliff Office Hours: 7425
 - Tue 11am-Noon or Fri 2:30-3:30pm; also by appointment!

More Intros

Tarraneh Eftekhari

CIERA Assistant Director, Research Faculty

Michail Damoulakis

CIERA Computational Specialist

More Intros



Vicky Kalogera

CIERA Director



Kiki Zissimopoulos

CIERA Director of Operations



William Vercellone

CIERA Information Coordinator



Janet Lyons

Financial Assistant

Intros: Other Programs

REACH: Research Experiences in Astronomy at
CIERA for High School Students

RET: Research Experience for Teachers
high school and middle school teachers

ISG: Illinois Space Grant
undergraduate summer research students (most from NU)

Other: research students and postbacs

Tech Setup

Eduroam WiFi & VPN Setup



<https://bit.ly/cierareu-eduroam>



<https://bit.ly/cierareu-vpn>

Logistics

- Dates: June 22 - August 22 (9 weeks)
- Desks: 1800 Sherman 8th floor
- Workshops: 1800 Sherman 7th floor 7-600
- Mentors in 1800 Sherman 7th + 8th floor or Tech
- Slack + Email (+ Zoom)
- Provided:
 - ID Card + NetID + Quest Accounts
 - Stipends + dorm housing + dining Cat Cash

*Note: lock-out = \$10, lost electronic key = \$25, lost physical key = \$250
(we will cover this within reason)*

Logistics

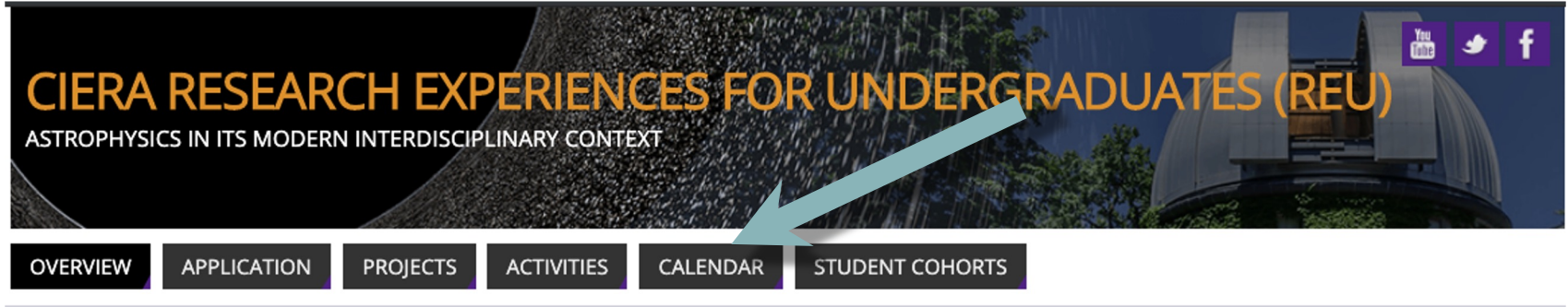
Stipends

- Set up Direct Deposit via myHR (due today!)
- Treated as scholarship: No W2 from Northwestern

Cat Cash on Housing / Conference Cards

- \$1000 initial balance, can increase to \$1600
- 2 meals, 5 days: $14.19 + 21.28 = \$35.47/\text{day}$, $\$177.35/\text{week}$
- Allison Dining Hall (1820 Chicago Ave) – Hours: 7:30am-9:30am, 11am-1:30pm, 5pm-7pm – Menu: dineoncampus.com/northwestern
- Other Venues: Norris (lunch today!)

Calendar



<https://bit.ly/cierareu-cal>



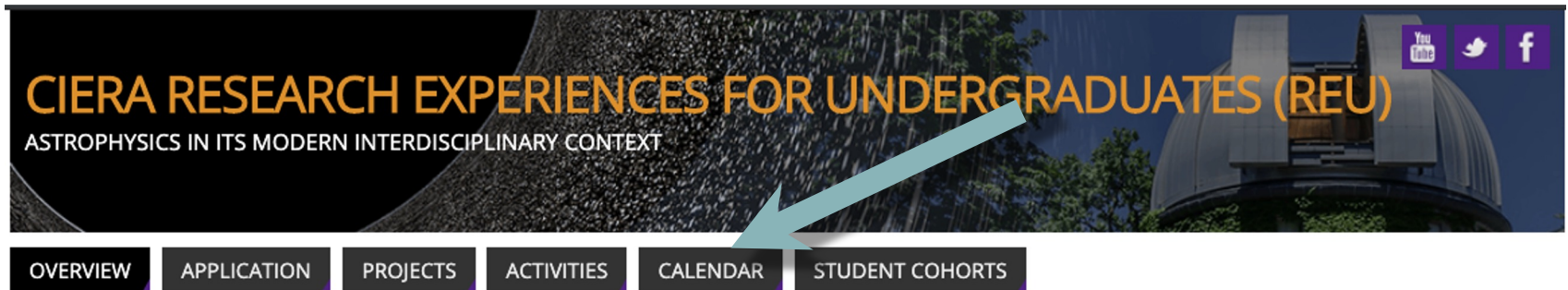
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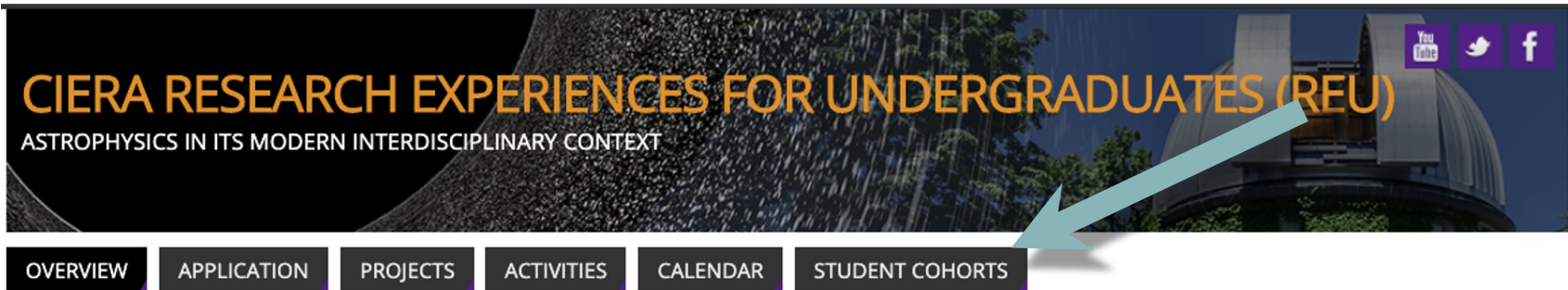
Professional Development

- Python programming workshops
- Quest, command line, GitHub, website tutorials
- RCTP science communication workshops
- Writing workshops
- Research seminars by NU researchers
- Grad school & Career Panel Discussions



Final Products

- Poster to present at January AAS meeting (Salt Lake City)
 - “Experts” poster session in person (August 20)
 - “General” presentations on Zoom (August 21)
 - Other poster session? (TBD)
- Project Summary in RNAAS style
- Research website, GitHub repo(s)
- Keep working with your advisor(s) remotely!



Community/Team Building

June 23 : REU Group Dinner

June 26 : Welcome Picnic with Summer Colleagues

July 11 : Field trip to the Adler Planetarium

July 15 : Field trip to Fermilab

July 29 : Field trip to Yerkes Observatory

Day 1 (Tuesday, June 23)

In your meeting with your mentor, remember to ask (at least) 5 of these questions (see Slack):

1. How did you get started in research?
2. What is some advice you got that has really stayed with you? Do you have a story of a time when it was applicable and influenced what you did or wished you had done?
3. What hobbies do you have? Do you have one you really miss? Is there one you still make regular time for?
4. What is a food that you really like? Why?
5. Would you tell me about a time when you did not succeed the way that you wanted to? What did you do or wish you had done then? What did you learn from that experience, and how has it shaped what you have done since?
6. What have your past students gone on to do career-wise?
7. What kinds of questions should I come to ask you vs. asking others in your group? How would you let me know if you think I'm asking a question you're not prepared to answer?
8. How do you handle things when something difficult or stressful has happened personally that causes you not to be able to focus? How might you let me know so I can be helpful and work well with you?
9. What are some of the other demands on your time this summer? How often would you like us to meet to talk? What do you expect that we will talk about when we meet?

Communication Options

Ask your mentor(s) their preferred form of communication.

We will use the following:

- **Slack**
 - Quick response time, short entries
 - Cohort channel
- **Email**
 - Longer wait time, but more permanent
 - Easier to search
- **Zoom + in-person**
 - Meetings, office hours, etc.

Communication Options

Slack Use: Channels

- #reu2026
- #announcements
- DMs

Code of Conduct

Our Code of Conduct:

https://github.com/CIERA-Northwestern/CIERA_REU/blob/main/code_of_conduct.pdf

Values:

Shared Responsibility, Honesty, Respect

Principles of Engagement:

raise all voices

no: feigning surprise, “well-actually”s, -isms

If you see or experience problematic behaviors: consider raising the issue in the moment, but you can also raise with REU leadership

If you err: apologize, reflect how you can learn, move on

Reporting: speak to or email Cliff, Mark, Tarraneh, Kiki

Also available: NU Title IX office, NU Office of the Ombudsperson

Safety Reminders

Contact Numbers

Cliff = 207-649-8955

Dorm Contact Numbers

Housing Office (business hours) = 847-467-7709

24/7 On Duty = 224-261-5043

Text Alerts

Text AlertNU to 226787 for a 365-day subscription
(or AlertNU7 / AlertNU30 for 7/30-day subscription)
opt out by texting STOP to the same number

Research Project Best Practices

- Communicating with your Mentor(s)
- Optimizing Your Progress
- Developing Independence



<https://bit.ly/cierareu-bestpractices>

See: https://github.com/CIERA-Northwestern/CIERA_REU/blob/main/orientation/student_best_practices.pdf

Self Care

Actively take care of your body and mind!

- Sleep well and enough
- Exercise (even just going for a walk)
- Keep up with personal hygiene
- Set a schedule and stick to it
- Set realistic goals for yourself
- Schedule non-work activities
- Talk with your cohort about things other than work
- Be kind to yourself

Links

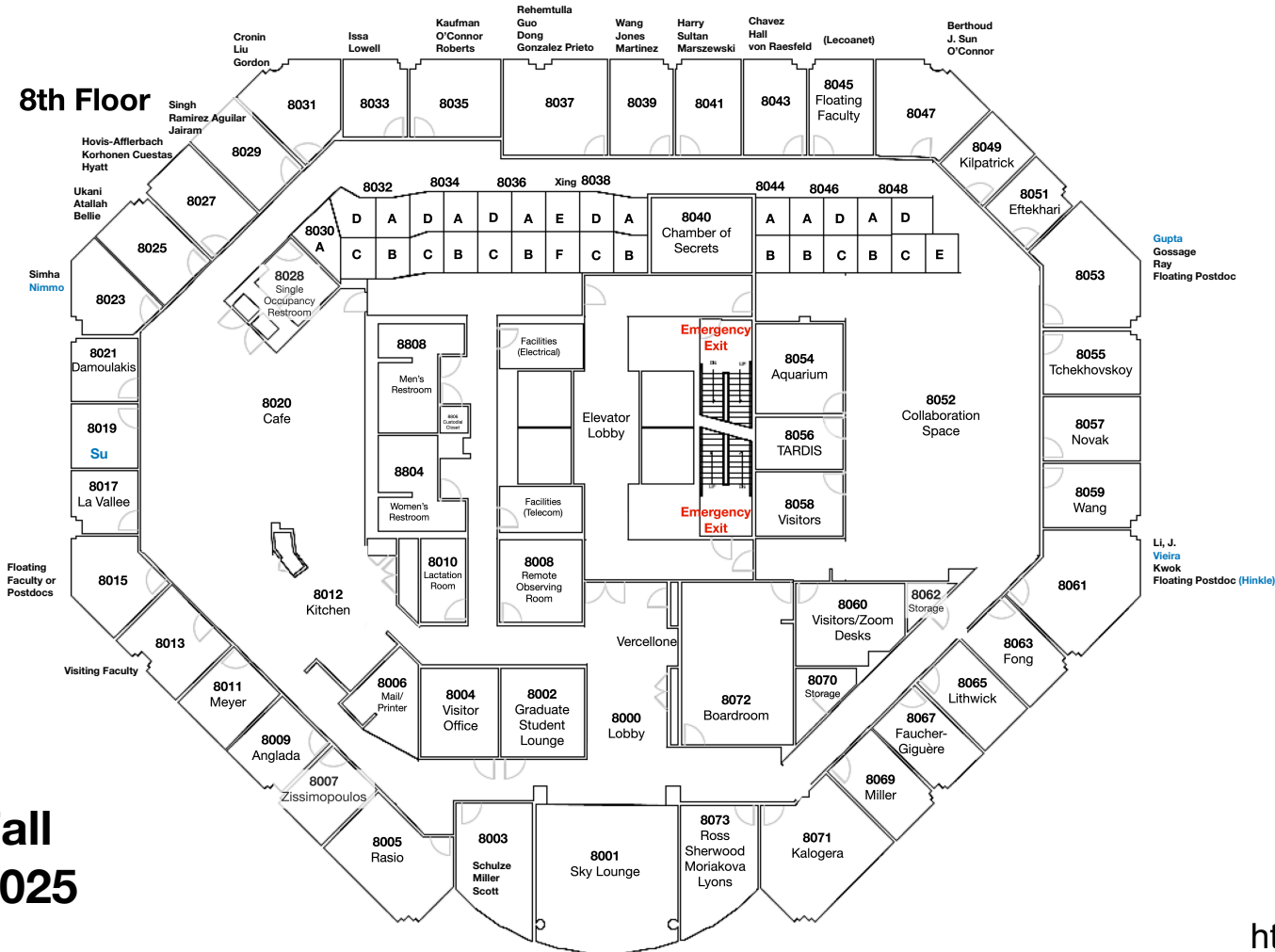


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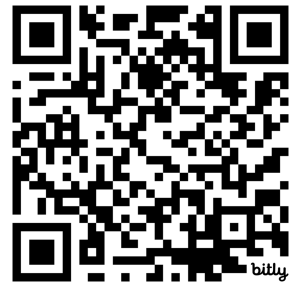
Tour: office space, campus, Norris



8th Floor

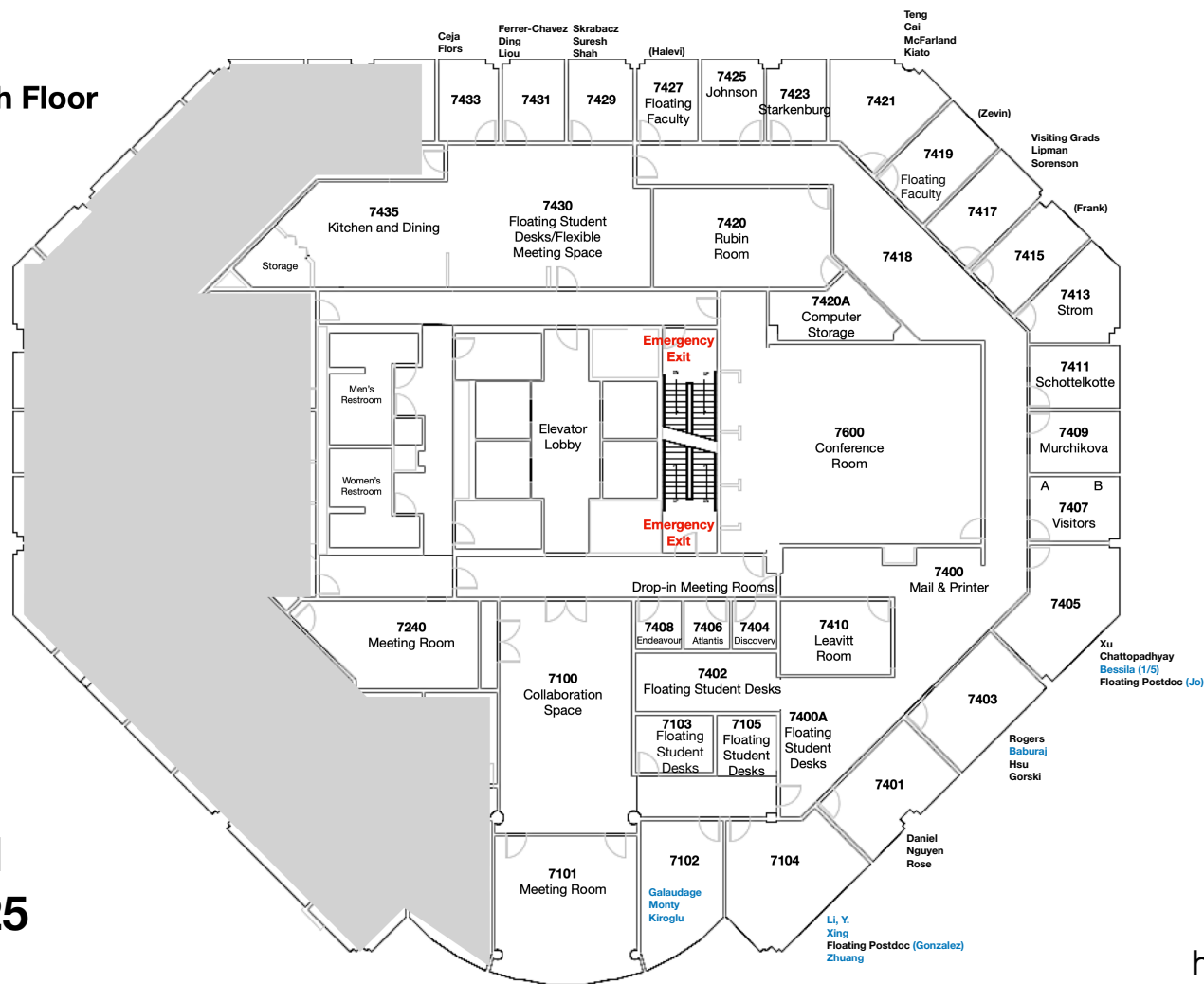


Fall
2025



<https://bit.ly/cierareu-map>

7th Floor



Fall
2025



<https://bit.ly/cierareu-map>

